GEOGRAPHY IN HISTORY

2.2 The Discoveries of Lewis and Clark

MAIN IDEA Lewis and Clark's expedition cleared up some of the geographic unknowns of the new, expansive lands that President Jefferson bought from France.

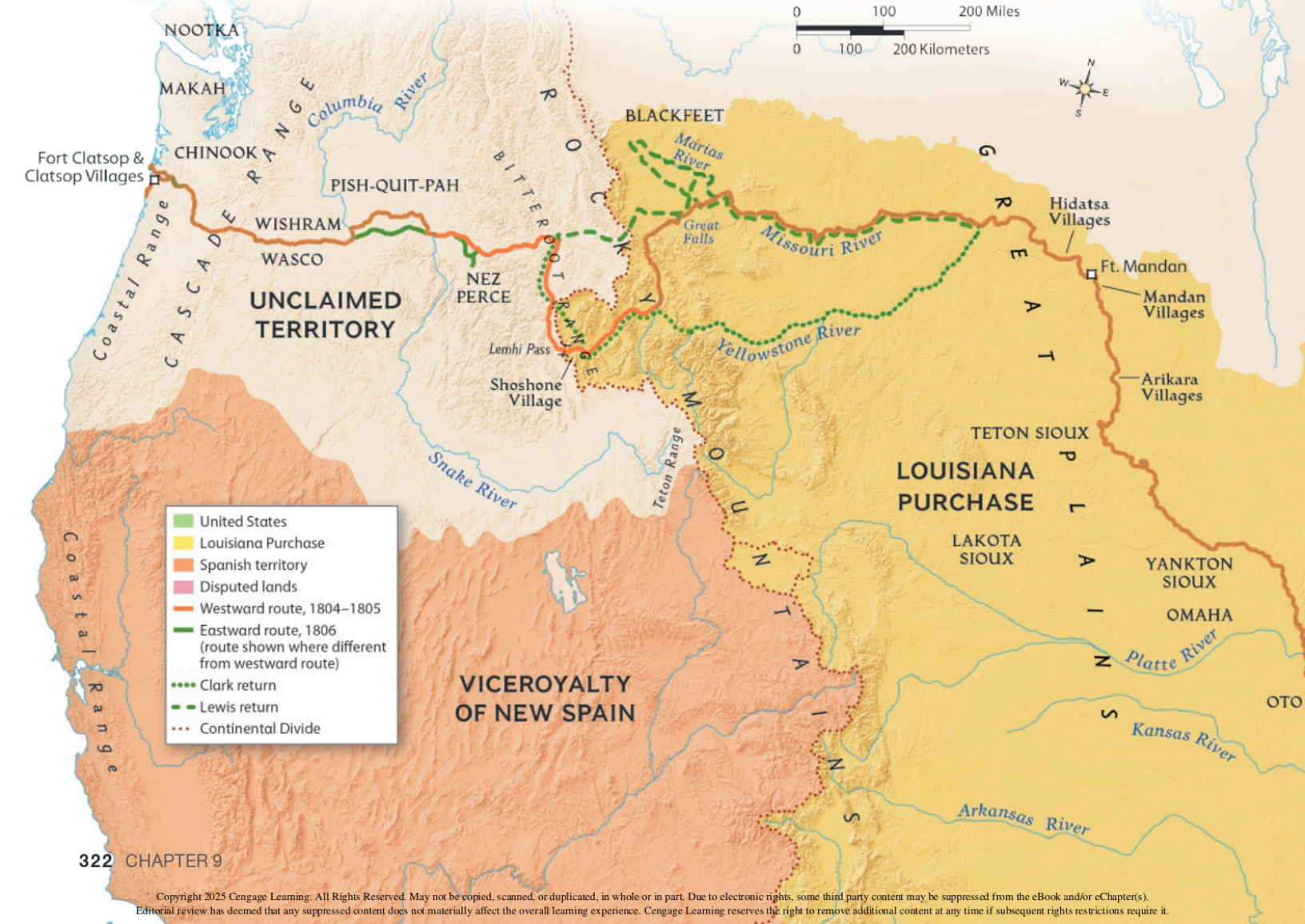
A SCIENTIFIC EXPEDITION

As you have read, Meriwether Lewis and William Clark's Corps of Discovery traveled almost 8,000 miles from St. Louis, Missouri, to the Pacific Ocean, then back to St. Louis. Few accurate maps of the West existed at that time, and there were many geographic unknowns about the region. Lewis and Clark's recorded observations changed Americans' understanding of the physical landscapes of the West.

Their journey also resulted in the discovery of plants and animals never seen before by European-Americans. Lewis and Clark recorded more than 120 new animal species, including mule deer and coyote. They described 178 new species of plants, like the big leaf maple, the Oregon crabapple, and the ponderosa pine.

Follow the journey of Lewis and Clark on the map below. Then read about three geographic unknowns in the West and the new geographic knowledge the explorers gained through their travels and observations.

Lewis and Clark's Expedition Route, 1804–1806



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GEOGRAPHIC UNKNOWN	GEOGRAPHIC KNOWLEDGE

THE MISSOURI RIVER AND THE MARIAS RIVER

In June 1805, Lewis and Clark were sailing up the Missouri River in present-day Montana when they came to another river. One river flowed from the north, and the other flowed from the south. Which one was the main stem of the Missouri River? Which one should they continue to follow?

Most members of Lewis and Clark's expedition wanted to follow the river that flowed from the north. Lewis and Clark were not so sure. They split up, with Clark scouting the river to the south and Lewis scouting the river to the north. They returned from their quick explorations and agreed—the south branch was the Missouri River and the one they should continue to follow upstream. Lewis named the river to the north the Marias River, after his cousin Maria.

THE NORTHWEST PASSAGE

Jefferson had hoped Lewis and Clark would find a Northwest Passage, a water route that would connect the Missouri River to the Pacific Ocean and the riches of Asia. The country that found such a route first would control it. When the explorers arrived at the origin of the Missouri River in August 1805, they expected to have a short portage to the Columbia River, which would carry them to the Pacific.

Lewis reached Lemhi Pass, a two-mile span bridging the gap between the ranges of the Rockies near the border of present-day Montana and Idaho. There, Lewis discovered "immence ranges of high mountains still to the West of us with their tops partially covered with snow." There would not be a short portage to the Columbia River. Instead, the expedition had to cross the rugged Bitterroot Mountains, which took them until October. The hopes for a Northwest Passage had died.

BISON

When Lewis and Clark embarked on their expedition, they knew about bison. However, they had no idea how large the herds were or how vital these animals were to the Native Americans of the Great Plains. They also didn't know where the bison roamed.

As Lewis and Clark traveled west, they found enormous herds of bison and, like the Native Americans, they came to depend on the bison for the animals' nutritious meat. The explorers found no bison west of the Rocky Mountains, but when they took different routes east through the Rockies, the bison reappeared.



THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

1. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How did Lewis and Clark determine that the Northwest Passage did not exist?
2. **ANALYZE ENVIRONMENTAL CONCEPTS** How might settlement in the lands obtained through the Louisiana Purchase affect the biological diversity of the plants and animals Lewis and Clark discovered?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** How did Lewis and Clark's perceptions of the West change as a result of their expedition?

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